Pre-video guide: from "no idea" to "ready to record"

Do this for **every** video, before you record. It takes about 2 hours (your Sunday block). It follows the roadmap: Phase 4 steps 1-3 (find the idea, package first, script) and the rules. The result is ONE brief file per video: `research/<yyyy-mm-dd>-<short-name>.md` (template at the bottom).

This guide does not choose your tests or your first videos. That is Phase 2. This is the repeatable routine for any video.

Before the first run (once, about 5 minutes)

1. **Open a new Claude Code session** in `D:\YTHELPER\gta-channel`. Commands are loaded when a session starts.
2. **yt-dlp** (`tools\bin\yt-dlp.exe`, official release, checksum verified) powers steps 1b and 1c. It has **not been tested on live YouTube yet**: Claude was not allowed to run it during setup. `/pre-video` starts it by itself through `collect.py`, which the command pre-approves, so you may **not** be asked. If you do not want it used, delete the file: the routine then does step 1a only. If 1b or 1c fail, copy the error line and send it to Claude. To test it yourself first, run the 2-command smoke test below.
3. **Fewer prompts (optional).** Paste the lines shown below this list under `allowed-tools:` in `.claude\commands\pre-video.md`. They let the command read your `voice.md` and run the plugin's scoring scripts without asking. Without them you approve 2-3 prompts per run, or the script is a neutral draft and the scores are labelled "manual estimate, tool not run".
4. **Give Claude your real voice.** Put a few paragraphs of how you actually talk into `~/.claude/youtube/voice.md` ("How I actually talk"). Until then every script is a neutral draft.

The lines for item 3 (copy them exactly, the stars are part of the rule):

```
  - Read(~/.claude/youtube/**)
  - Read(~/.claude/plugins/cache/youtube-agent-skill/**)
  - PowerShell(python *title.py*)
  - PowerShell(python *hookscore.py*)
  - PowerShell(python *swipe.py*)
  - Bash(python *title.py*)
  - Bash(python *hookscore.py*)
  - Bash(python *swipe.py*)
```

Smoke test for steps 1b and 1c (optional, 2 minutes). In your own terminal, in the project folder, with small numbers:

```
python tools\collect.py niche "gta 5 police chase" --channels 2 --videos 10 -o research\smoke-niche.json
python tools\collect.py comments <any video url from that json file> --max 50
```

Paste the output to Claude. If it fails: an error about a **JavaScript runtime** is a known one-flag fix in `collect.py` (`--js-runtimes node`). "Sign in to confirm you're not a bot" is YouTube slowing you down, not a bug: wait and retry with smaller numbers. Anything else: send Claude the error line. Delete `research\smoke-niche.json` afterwards.

Two ways to use it

A. One command (easiest). Open Claude Code in this folder and type:

```
/pre-video <one sentence idea, or: no idea yet, game: GTA 5>
```

Claude does steps 0-6 alone and saves the brief in `research/` and a **PDF in `output/`** (same name). It does not stop at the checkpoints. It picks the top 3 ideas, develops the best, and gives a GO/NO-GO as a *recommendation*. The two human calls (would I click it? my own words?) are in a "You decide before recording" box at the top of the PDF.

A2. Step by step with Claude. If you want to decide at each checkpoint yourself, paste:

```
Follow PRE-VIDEO-GUIDE.md for this idea: <one sentence, or "I have no idea yet, game: GTA 5">.
Do steps 1-6 in order. Stop at every CHECKPOINT and wait for me. Save the brief in research/.
```

B. Do it yourself, step by step, using the commands below.

Step 0: What is the idea? (2 min)

Write it as **a question + how you will answer it**:

> "How fast do the cops arrive after a minor crime?" + "I measure it 10 times in the same place and take the average."

No idea? Use these sources: your content pillars in `CLAUDE.md`, the comments in step 1c, and the search suggestions in step 1a.

Step 1: Look at YouTube first (20 min)

Always look before you decide. You are looking for three things.

1a. What people type into YouTube search

```
python tools/collect.py suggest "gta 6 cops"
```

Use a short seed (2-3 words). Long phrases return nothing. Top block = most typed. Every line is a possible title or idea. It shows US-English results (your target audience). To see another country add `--region bd` (or `gb`, `in`...).

1b. What already works (needs yt-dlp in `tools/bin`)

```
python tools/collect.py niche "gta 5 police chase test" -o research/<name>-niche.json
```

then in Claude Code: `/yt-viral research/<name>-niche.json`

It ranks every video by **how far it beat its own channel's usual views** (not by channel size). Read:

- the top 5 and their multiple (2x or more is a signal)
- the one thing they share (format? question? number in the title?)
- the gap: what does nobody show **with real data**? That gap is your idea.

1c. What viewers ask for (needs yt-dlp)

```
python tools/collect.py comments <url of one of the top videos>
```

The "look like requests" list = free video ideas ("can you test...?"). Roadmap rule 7: comments are your idea database.

What this cannot tell you: other people's click rate or retention. You only see public views. Views are a signal, not proof. Do not copy a video: take the structure and add your own test data. That data is what nobody can copy. If a channel has fewer than 4 videos collected, `/yt-viral` skips it (a median needs 4+).

> **CHECKPOINT 1.** Pick ONE idea. If two are tied, pick the one you can test fairly.

Step 2: Does it fit? (5 min)

All answers must be yes. If one is no, go back to step 1.

- ☐ Fits a pillar: Experiment, Systems explained, Developer x AI, or a Short?
- ☐ ONE clear question and ONE clear answer? (rule 3)
- ☐ Can the **same test** be run again in GTA 6, with the same rules?
- ☐ Fair test: same time of day, weather, place and vehicle class; repeat 5-10 times and use the average
- ☐ Not news, a rumor, a leak, or a fake "secret"? No story spoilers in title/thumbnail?
- ☐ Every GTA 6 fact you need is in `gta6-notes.md` (official source)? Unknown features phrased as a **question**, not a claim?

Step 3: Package first (30 min): title + thumbnail, before recording

Rule 1: if you cannot make it clickable, **do not make the video.**

In Claude Code: `/yt-package` with your idea and the best lines from step 1.

- It writes 10 titles and keeps the top 3 with scores. Check: under 60 characters (40 for mobile), has a number or name, no vague words.
- It writes a thumbnail brief: **max 3 words**, and the words must **not repeat the title**.
- Make the thumbnail in Canva yourself. Your masked < > character goes in a corner.

> **CHECKPOINT 2.** Look at the title + thumbnail at small size. Would YOU click? No? Pick another idea.

Step 4: Hook and script (45 min)

In Claude Code: `/yt-script`. It writes 5 hooks, scores them, shows the best 2.

- Hook score under 55 (WEAK): rewrite. A high score is not a promise, a low score means look again.
- Rule 2: the **first 30 seconds show the stakes or the result.** No intro, no logo, no "hey guys".
- Every beat has `[ON SCREEN: ...]`, so you are never just a talking head.
- Then **rewrite it in your own words and read it aloud.** The script is a draft. Your voice is your face (rule 6).
- Every number in the script must come from `test-results.csv` or a source. Claude must never invent one.

Step 5: Search text (15 min)

In Claude Code: `/yt-seo`.

- The first **two lines** of the description are what people see. Say what the video gives them, in the words they type (from step 1a).
- Write the 3 searches this video should win. Check the title contains those words.
- Tags: 15 at most. They matter little. Chapters come after editing (`/yt-chapters`).

Step 6: Test plan + recording check (10 min)

- ☐ Write the exact test rules in the brief (conditions from step 2). They must be identical every run.
- ☐ You know which `test-results.csv` columns you will fill after each run (date, game, patch, test_id, run, metric, value, unit, time_of_day, weather, location, vehicle, footage_file, notes).
- ☐ OBS: mic level OK, scene OK, saves to `D:\obsVideo`. Record a 10-second test and play it back.
- ☐ A clear file name per run, and the same name goes in the `footage_file` column.

GO / NO-GO

GO only if **all** are true: you have a clickable title + thumbnail, a hook that shows the result in 30 seconds, a fair repeatable test, and facts that come from a source or your own data. Otherwise: NO-GO. Go back to step 1 with a new idea. Finishing videos beats perfect videos (rule 8), but a video nobody clicks teaches you nothing.

Next: record, then follow "Production pipeline" in `CLAUDE.md` (transcribe, rough cut, Resolve, Shorts). After a week: `/yt-retention`, and write ONE lesson.

Notes

- **Before GTA 6 launches (2026-11-19)** there is almost no GTA 6 test content, so research the GTA 5 / "experiments" niche. After launch, run step 1 again with GTA 6 queries to see what early winners look like.

- Do not run `niche` too often or with huge numbers. Defaults (8 channels, 30 videos each) are enough. It only reads public pages and never logs in.
- No yt-dlp? Do step 1a only. For 1b, paste 4+ recent videos (title + views) per channel into the chat and `/yt-viral` can work from that list.

If something goes wrong

What you see	What it means	What to do
No PDF in `output\`	The brief was written but the PDF step failed	The brief is in `research\`. Run `uv run tools/make_pdf.py research/<name>.md`. If it still fails, close all Edge windows and retry
"yt-dlp not found" / "yt-dlp failed"	Steps 1b/1c could not run	The PDF says what was skipped. Step 1a still works. Send Claude the error line
Scores say "manual estimate, tool not run"	The plugin scripts were not allowed to run	Add the permission lines in "Before the first run", or approve the prompts
Script says "neutral draft, not my voice"	`voice.md` was empty or unreadable	Add your speech samples to `~/.claude/youtube/voice.md`
Claude says NO-GO	Its recommendation on the plan, not a rule	Read the reason in the PDF. You decide

Brief template (copy to `research/<yyyy-mm-dd>-<short-name>.md`)

```
# <working title>
Date:            Game: GTA 5 / GTA 6      Pillar:
Idea (question + how answered):
Why now / what the research showed (3 lines, with the multiples you saw):
Search phrases people use (from 1a):
Requests from comments (from 1c):

Title (chosen):                Alternatives:
Thumbnail (max 3 words, not the title):
Hook (chosen) + score:
Script: link or paste
Description first 2 lines:     3 target searches:

Test rules (identical every run):
  time of day / weather / location / vehicle:   runs planned (5-10):
Facts used + their source (gta6-notes.md line or test-results.csv rows):

GO / NO-GO:   Reason:
After a week (fill later): CTR / first-30s retention / returning viewers / ONE lesson:
```